CAMEMBERT DE NORMANDIE PDO



THE BASICS

MAKE:	Soft
SUB MAKE:	Predominantly Rennet set cheese for further ripening
POST-MAKE:	External mould/yeast ripened
SUB POST-MAKE:	Predominantly Penicillium candidum
TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	One month
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	250g
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	Departments of Orne, Manche, Eure, Calvados in Normandy, France
PROTECTED STATUS:	PDO - must be made with raw cows' milk in the Normandy region
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Cow
BREED OF COW:	Cow. At least 50% of the herd must be Normande breed cows
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Raw cows' milk
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Typically animal rennet
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	N/A

THE STORY

The story goes that Marie Harel, a farmer's wife in Normandy, invented Camembert in 1791 after sheltering a priest on the run during the French Revolution. A native of Brie, the priest was said to have taught her the recipe for a soft, bloomy cheese in return for help. However, there is no evidence to support the story and there are actually much earlier references to Camembert.

The term 'Camembert' is not protected so can be used all over the world, but 'Camembert de Normandie' must be produced in Normandy with raw milk from herds with at least 50% Normande cows. The breed is prized for producing milk that is rich in protein and butterfat. Curds are cut vertically then ladled into moulds in five scoops, each one 40 minutes after the last. The cheeses drain for at least 18 hours and are turned once.

THE CHARACTER

Young cheeses have a chalky texture, but soften as they age, ripening from the Penicillium camemberti rind inwards. In Normandy, a chalky heart is welcomed, but elsewhere people prefer it ripened all the way through. The flavour tends to be stronger and more rustic than Brie de Meaux with intense vegetal and earthy notes. A strong aroma of ammonia is a sign the cheese has been over-ripened.

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PERFECT PARTNERS:

Try a buttery white burgundy, while spicy saison beers provide contrast.

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